# Palatia libris: a remediação digital da Biblioteca Joanina Palatia libris: digital remediation of the Joanina Library

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The last two decades have witnessed significant digitization efforts and the creation of digital libraries, which have benefited from technological advancements related not only to the process of capturing and making images available, but also to the possibility of offering new services to users. In other words, beyond simply providing digitized works, which involves complex technical aspects, particularly in large-scale digitization projects, there is a growing emphasis on ensuring the usability of digital content and leveraging the research potential of digital collections. This potential is inseparable from data models, search tools, and the interfaces provided.

These concerns are at the core of the **Digital Joanina Project** ( **DJP**), guided by the principles of accessibility and open science. An initiative of the **University of Coimbra** ( **UC**) with the patronage of the Sharjah Book Authority (SBA), the DJP, having just completed its pilot stage, aims to digitize approximately 30,000 old books from the Noble Floor of the Joanina Library, whose building is part of a UNESCO World Heritage Site (The University of Coimbra – Alta and Sofia).

This study employs remediation theory (Bolter / Grusin 1999) to critically examine the implications of digitizing a historic library. Digital facsimiles, machine-readable text, and file structures can be conceptualized as remediations of printed books, while the assemblage formed by metadata, database, search and retrieval functions, and interfaces may be described as remediations of the library itself. We highlight the research dimension of digitization, reflecting on the implementation process, the technical and practical specificities involved, and the contributions expected for both researchers and the general public, namely the development of new resources, including a platform for managing and publishing collections of digital objects.

Framing the digitization of a historic library's collections through remediation theory allows us to critically examine various levels of mediation: the digital reconfiguration of books, collections, the library itself, and user interactions (librarians, researchers, general readers) with digital objects. Facsimile reproduction through images, the conversion of works into searchable text, and the creation of metadata for both the originals and the digital objects themselves are examples of the reconfiguration of the bibliographic structures of the printed medium in accordance with the operating principles of the digital medium. Furthermore, the functioning of interfaces as enunciative media devices — i.e. constitutive of certain subject positions (Drucker 2020) — enables us to further reflect on the remediation of readers resulting from the remediation of *book palaces*. From the interplay between functionalities and the visual rhetoric of the interfaces, the new public face of Joanina will emerge.

First, this paper will contextualize the DJP within recent global efforts to digitize rare and special collections, acknowledging the significant and demonstrated benefits of such projects both for cultural heritage preservation and for democratizing knowledge by providing online access to otherwise inaccessible texts.

The more global dimension of digitization will be analyzed, as well as the political and geopolitical dimensions of mass digitization, which are not immune to criticism (Coyle 2006; Thylstrup 2018). At the same time, we will consider the local dimension and the role that physical libraries continue and should continue to play. Previous

experience shows, for example, that making a particular special collection available online can stimulate demand and contribute to library attendance (Ceynowa 2009).

It is understood that digitizing the Joanina's core collections will yield deeper insights into the library itself, enabling a holistic study and exploration — for example, through data mining using artificial intelligence tools. In this sense, the DJP is concerned with digitizing and providing access to complete collections, recognized for their high research potential.

Among these, the 13,989-volume miscellany collection stands out for its importance and rarity, featuring funeral prayers, academic eulogies, sermons, panegyrics, etc. Originally sourced from bibliophile José Pedro Hasse de Belém (a high dignitary of the Lisbon Church), it was further enriched in 1989 with 240 volumes of theater-related miscellanies and continues to grow through occasional acquisitions. Its high demand by national and European researchers justifies its prioritization (Amaral 2014: 51ff; Pereira / Bogalho 2019).

The DJP benefits from previous digitization efforts carried out since 2005 at the **General Library of the University of Coimbra** ( **BGUC**), notably *AlmaMater* , the UC's digital library of old books, launched in 2010 (Silva et al. 2019). The third section of this paper will address this process of incorporating technological changes at BGUC, aimed at improving functionality and sustainability to better serve its target audiences and the broader community.

UC must harness technological innovations and adapt to changes in the type and volume of information created. Semantic Web representations are appropriate for structuring data from the university's digital resources and linking them to external databases, enabling versatile access through multiple applications (Koch et al. 2023).

The DJP extends beyond digitization: it aims to create a scalable platform for future projects, seamlessly integrated with an infrastructure capable of incorporating content from various UC sources, presenting new functionalities, and adopting a Linked Open Data-based representation model, using and/or adapting appropriate ontologies and vocabularies (Park / Kipp 2019). Among other goals, it seeks to achieve interoperability with other internal and external platforms (Emanuel 2018), particularly by integrating the future Digital Joanina collections into the Europeana portal.

During the pilot stage, BGUC established digitization workflows, quality control criteria, and technical cataloguing guidelines, while also investing in staff training for digitization validation and cataloging. The collection selected for the pilot stage — focused on the Middle East — has undergone detailed bibliographic processing to create consistent metadata that ensures efficient information retrieval and the organization of the collection. Finally, regarding the platform to be developed, the Digital Joanina Working Group has produced global requirement documentation. These and other documents and workflows will be addressed in order to highlight the challenges of BGUC's current project and the solutions found to overcome them.

The DJP represents a transformation in how UC manages and shares its documentary heritage. The pilot stage's primary contribution lies in documenting and analyzing the development of these new digital resources. Other expected outcomes include advancing the preservation of the Joanina Library's heritage; making available a robust and interoperable technological platform, capable of integrating and enhancing diverse content; fostering interdisciplinary research by enabling new ways of analyzing and exploring data; refining applicable metrics for similar collections, and democratizing access to the special collections of Joanina and the UC, achieved through the creation of accessible digital tools designed to meet the needs of the scientific community and the general public.

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